

Do any of these sayings sound familiar to you? “Money can’t buy happiness.” “Money is the root of all evil.” “More money, more problems.”

In America, we’ve been raised to believe that money indeed can’t buy happiness. That doesn’t stop us from trying, though, as we spend on all kinds of questionable health remedies, get-rich-quick scams, and pointless fads. What’s even funnier is how we show our ambivalence toward money. For example, have you ever noticed that Americans love rich people who pretend to have no money? Take Warren Buffett: “Oh wow, you live in a modest house from 1969! That’s so relatable!” (Let’s ignore your private jet.) Or Bill Gates: “You wear Dockers, just like my dad!” (Let’s ignore your 66,000-square-foot mansion.)

We even create an identity around how we *don’t* spend money: We proudly tell people that even if we had millions of dollars, we would never spend on certain clothes or fancy restaurants. (Think of that! An identity of what we *wouldn’t* do instead of an identity around what we *want* to do.)

But I believe money can be an amazing force for good. It can help you buy back your time, experience new things, and be more generous with the people around you.

It can also make you happier.

Surprisingly, this is a radical concept: the idea that instead of focusing on restriction and cutting back, you should start with using money to create your Rich Life.

When you accurately identify what you love spending money on, it becomes easy to cut back mercilessly on the things you don’t love (because you have a clearer reason to).

Let me show you how this looks in my life. Growing up, we never ordered appetizers. So one of my first Rich Life moments was deciding that if I saw an appetizer I wanted, I would order it. Later, I decided that if I was going to a meeting on a hot, sweaty summer day in NYC, I would take a taxi, not the subway.

I call these spending habits Money Dials, or the areas of life you *love* to spend money on. Notice that I’m not talking about how to save \$0.34 per month by disabling your oven light. And I’m not showing you some complicated math formula to understand compounding. Remember, in personal finance, we overvalue math and undervalue psychology.